ASSISTANT MANAGER ESSENTIALS: LEVEL 1

Assistant Manager Essentials: Level 1 — Level 1: Assistant Manager Essentials — Day 2: Running the Day

Study guide · Self-study

Level 1: Assistant Manager Essentials · Day 2: Running the Day

How to Use This Guide

This guide is for Day 2 of the Assistant Manager Essentials course. It teaches you how to run a working day: how to sort the day's work, how to plan it in blocks, how to open and close the day, how to turn an instruction into a short written brief, how to delegate with an agreed follow-up rhythm, and how to run a short daily huddle.

Read one section at a time. Write as you go. When a section asks you to practice, do it with your real work list, your real tasks and your real conversations. You do not need a team of your own, a manager sitting with you, or any special data. If you are not an Assistant Manager yet, each exercise gives you a version that fits your current role as a team member, senior staff member or Team Leader.

Complete the "What Would You Say?" exercises in writing before you read the Model Answers. Your words should sound like you, not like a script.

Day 1 taught you what the role is and how to decide what is inside your authority. That matters today. A plan for the day is only useful if you know which items you own and which you escalate.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know the difference between urgent and important work, the purpose of daily planning blocks and opening and closing routines, the four parts of a short written brief, and what a follow-up rhythm agreed at handover looks like.

Attitude: You will treat planning, briefing and a short daily huddle as core parts of the role, not as paperwork that gets in the way of real work.

Skill: You will be able to sort your day's work by urgency and importance, write a short brief with outcome, steps, deadline and checkpoints, and agree a follow-up rhythm with a colleague at handover.

Upskill: You will be able to run a daily huddle that ends with clear ownership and a deadline on every item, while keeping it short.

Urgency and Importance: Why the Loudest Item Wins

Most people start the day with good intentions. By mid-morning, the loudest thing on their desk has taken over. That is not a character flaw. It is how attention works.

Think about how you experience a busy day. Something arrives with a raised voice, a red mark or a repeated message. Your body reacts before your thinking does. The fast, automatic part of your mind treats "recent and vivid" as "important," and the calm, deliberate part has to be called in on purpose. In his book Thinking, Fast and Slow, Daniel Kahneman calls these two modes System 1 and System 2. System 1 is quick and effortless. System 2 is slow and takes effort. Most of your day runs on System 1 unless you interrupt it.

That is why a customer call that can wait until Thursday can grab your whole morning, while the brief you promised a colleague by Friday sits untouched. The urgent item feels bigger than it is. The important item does not protest.

Sorting work by how soon it has to be done and what it affects is an old and tested habit. In The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People, Stephen Covey puts urgency and importance on two separate axes and urges you to live in the important-but-not-urgent quadrant. Do that and the crises that arrive are fewer, because you handled them while they were still quiet.

Here is the practical move. At the start of each day, write each item on one line and mark two things: how soon it truly has to be done, and what it affects if it slips. Some items are both urgent and important, and those go first. Some are important but not urgent, and those need a block in your calendar or they will never happen. Some are urgent but not very important, and those are good to delegate or do quickly in a short gap. Some are neither, and those you question whether to do at all.

The psychology behind writing it down is simple. Once an item is on paper, your mind stops rehearsing it. You no longer spend effort remembering it, and you can compare items side by side instead of one at a time. That comparison is what lets you spot whether you are choosing by importance or just by noise.

Practice example: An Assistant Manager has eight items on a Monday. Two need to go out before noon because a customer is waiting. Three feed Friday's proposal, so they are important but have slack. Two are small requests from colleagues that can be done or handled by someone else today. One is a report nobody has asked for, and it waits or gets dropped. She plans the two customer items first, books a block for the proposal work, and clears the small requests in a fifteen-minute gap after lunch.

> **NOTES**
>
> Watch for the common mistake of treating everything that arrived today as urgent. Ask yourself what genuinely gets worse if the item waits until tomorrow.

Daily Planning Blocks: Deciding Before the Day Decides for You

A planning block is a short, protected piece of time where you decide the day's order and write it down. You do it once at the start of the day and once near the end, and it takes minutes, not an hour.

The reason it works is about what you decide and when you decide it. If you decide the order of the day in the middle of a busy morning, you decide under pressure, and pressure pushes you toward whatever is easiest or loudest. If you decide beforehand, you decide calmly, before the noise arrives. You make one good decision about your day instead of dozens of rushed ones.

Your morning block does four things. You look at what came in since yesterday. You sort the items by urgency and importance. You place the important-but-not-urgent work into a named block in your calendar. Then you choose your first item of the day and start it without checking anything else.

Your end-of-day block is just as important. You close open loops: note what is unfinished, write down where you left it, and set the first item for tomorrow. This gives your mind permission to stop working on it overnight. People who skip this step carry the whole list home in their heads and arrive tired.

Keep your planning block short and make it the same each day. A routine removes the need to decide whether to plan.

> **NOTES**
>
> If your days vary a lot, plan blocks for the two or three things that must happen, and leave room for what arrives. A plan full to the minute breaks on contact.

Opening and Closing Routines

An opening routine is how you start the day. A closing routine is how you finish it. They are small habits that give you control of the edges of the day.

Why the edges? Because the start of the day sets the direction and the end of the day sets your state for the evening and the next morning. If you begin by reacting to whatever appears first, you hand the day to whoever sent the first message. If you begin by choosing your first item, you set the tone.

A simple opening routine looks like this. Review what came in overnight. Confirm your top items. Check anything you promised someone else today. Then start your first item before you open message apps.

A simple closing routine looks like this. Update your work list. Note anything unfinished and where it stands. Write tomorrow's first item. Save your notes in a place you can find them, because a record you cannot find is not a record.

There is one more reason to close the day properly. In his book The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People, Stephen Covey describes trust as working like an emotional bank account: kept promises and courtesies are deposits, and letdowns are withdrawals. If you end the day noting a promise you made and haven't kept, you can act on it before your colleague has to remind you. That is a deposit. If you don't, it becomes a withdrawal when they chase you.

Practice example: An Assistant Manager's closing routine takes eight minutes. She updates her work list, writes one line on what is unfinished and what it needs, writes tomorrow's first item, and checks for any promise she made that day still open. She sends one short message: "I said I would send the brief tonight. I will send it by ten tomorrow morning; the delay does not affect your start." That message is the deposit.

> **NOTES**
>
> A closing routine is not for long reflection. Eight to ten minutes is enough. If it takes longer than that, you are still working, not closing.

Turning an Instruction into a Short Written Brief

An instruction you received in a corridor or on a call is not yet clear. It has a task in it, but often no outcome, no deadline and no way to check progress. When you pass that instruction to someone

else in the same state, you are relying on them guessing what you meant. Some guess well. The rest come back later, and the day gets spent on rework.

A short written brief fixes this with four parts: outcome, steps, deadline, checkpoints. Each part answers one question. The outcome answers "what does done look like?" The steps answer "how, roughly?" The deadline answers "by when?" The checkpoints answer "when will we look at it together?"

The psychology here is that people work better toward a clear, specific target. In their long-running research summary, Edwin Locke and Gary Latham showed that specific, challenging goals with feedback raise performance compared with vague ones. "Get it done soon" is vague. "Send the customer a corrected quote by Thursday noon, and check with me on Wednesday before you send" is specific, and it tells the person when feedback will come.

Keep it short. Four lines is plenty. The point is not to write a manual. The point is to remove the questions before they are asked.

Practice example: A manager says at the door, "Can you sort out the delivery issue with the north warehouse?" The Assistant Manager writes back to the manager, and to the colleague who will help: "Outcome: confirmed delivery date for the north customer, in writing. Steps: check stock with the warehouse, call the customer with the date, note the answer on the account. Deadline: Wednesday noon. Checkpoints: I will check with you Wednesday morning before the call." Four lines, no room for guessing.

> **NOTES**
>
> A short brief is not a document for approval. It is a short message that makes the work clear. Check with anyone whose approval is needed for the deadline.

Delegating with a Follow-Up Rhythm Agreed at Handover

Delegating is not dropping work on someone. It is handing over the outcome, the steps, the deadline and the checkpoints, and agreeing before the handover ends how you will both keep in touch.

Why the agreed rhythm matters: people who are given a task with no agreed check-in have two choices. They either interrupt you with questions, or they work in silence and hope their guess was right. Both cost the day. The first costs yours. The second costs rework. An agreed rhythm removes both, because you and the colleague already know when the next contact happens.

Agree it in three short pieces. When will the first check-in be? What will you both have ready by then? How does the colleague reach you if something goes wrong before then? Write the answers in the handover message so it exists outside both your heads.

There is one more rule that matters. At handover, say plainly what is inside your authority and what is not. If the colleague needs a decision outside your authority, they should raise it to you early, and you escalate it with a recommendation. That rule came up on Day 1, and it works the same at handover.

Practice example: An Assistant Manager hands over a small account update to a colleague. She writes: "You own the update. First check-in is tomorrow at ten; you will have the draft and I will have the customer's last email. If a price change comes up, do not agree it. Message me and I will escalate it with a recommendation the same day. If you cannot reach me, call me, or message my manager." Three pieces of rhythm, and one authority line.

> **NOTES**
>
> If you are not an Assistant Manager yet, delegate to yourself with the same steps: write the outcome, the deadline and a check-in with yourself, and record it on your work list.

The Short Daily Team Huddle

A huddle is a short stand-up meeting for the team, usually at the start of the day or the shift. Its job is not to update everyone on everything. Its job is to make the day's work clear: who owns what, by when, and who needs help.

The huddle needs one rule above all. It ends when every item has an owner and a deadline. An item that ends with "we should look into that" has not been handled. It will come back tomorrow, a little bigger.

Why keep it short? Because the longer a meeting runs, the more it becomes a place to repeat status and less a place to decide. Short meetings keep attention on what needs deciding. Long ones let people settle into talking about work instead of doing it.

A working structure: one line on what the day holds, one line from each person on what they are on and what they need, and a clear close on any item that came up. If an item needs more discussion, name two people and a time to discuss it after the huddle. That keeps the huddle short and the discussion real.

The psychology of the huddle is about commitment. When a person says out loud in front of their team "I will have this done by noon," they feel a small social pressure to keep the word. Small public commitments help people follow through. They also make it easy to notice early when someone is stuck.

Practice example: A five-person team huddle lasts twelve minutes. Each person states their main item and whether they need help. One item comes up as "the missing invoice" with no owner. Before the huddle closes, the Assistant Manager asks who will own it and by when, and the group agrees on one person and a deadline of two o'clock. The meeting ends on time with nothing left unnamed.

> **NOTES**
>
> Do not use the huddle to give feedback on a person. Feedback about behavior belongs in a private one-to-one, and you will practice that on Day 3. Keep the huddle about the day's work.

Apply It in Your Role

Start by sorting today's work. Write your items on separate lines, mark what truly has to be done and what it affects, and choose your first item. Then plan your blocks: a short morning block and a short end-of-day block. Run an opening and a closing routine, and keep both short.

Next, pick one instruction you have received recently and rewrite it as a four-line brief: outcome, steps, deadline, checkpoints. Use it in your next handover.

Finally, try one short huddle, or one short stand-up in whatever form your team already uses. Make sure every item ends with an owner and a deadline.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before reading the Model Answers.

1. Your manager hands you a task at the door and walks away. You want to turn it into a short brief before you do anything. What do you write, and to whom?

2. Your day has two customer items with a hard noon deadline, three items that feed Friday's proposal, and four small requests from colleagues. How do you sort and plan the day?

3. A colleague takes over part of your work this afternoon. What do you agree with them before the handover ends, and in what words?

4. A huddle item finishes with "we should look into that." You are running the huddle. What do you say to close it?

5. A colleague asks you to approve a small change to a customer's order, and the approval is outside your authority. What do you do, and what do you write?

Key Takeaways

- Sort the day's work by how soon it truly has to be done and what it affects, not by what is loudest.
- A short morning planning block and a short end-of-day block decide the day's order before the day decides it for you.
- Opening and closing routines give you control of the edges of the day and keep your promises visible.
- A short written brief has four parts: outcome, steps, deadline, checkpoints.
- Agree the follow-up rhythm at handover: first check-in, what each side will have ready, and how to reach you if something goes wrong.
- A huddle ends when every item has an owner and a deadline. Keep it short, and keep feedback about a person out of it.
- Never promise or approve something outside your authority. Escalate it early with a recommendation.

Quiz

Answer the five questions. Choose one option for each.

1. Which item should you generally do first in the day?
   - **A.** The item that is both urgent now and important.
   - **B.** The item that has just arrived with the most noise.
   - **C.** The easiest item, to build momentum.
   - **D.** The item you enjoy most.
2. What is the main purpose of an end-of-day planning block?
   - **A.** To finish the work you did not finish in the day.
   - **B.** To write a long report on the day.
   - **C.** To note what is unfinished, write tomorrow's first item, and close open loops.
   - **D.** To plan the following week in detail.
3. Which four parts belong in a short written brief?
   - **A.** Greeting, task, thanks, signature.
   - **B.** Outcome, steps, deadline, checkpoints.
   - **C.** Budget, people, risks, approvals.
   - **D.** Reason, history, options, decision.
4. What should you agree at handover with a colleague who takes over work?
   - **A.** That they will not contact you until the work is finished.
   - **B.** The first check-in time, what each side will have ready, and how to reach you.
   - **C.** The full history of the task.
   - **D.** That you will do the work yourself if it slips.
5. A huddle item ends with "we should look into that." What closes it properly?
   - **A.** Leaving it for tomorrow's huddle.
   - **B.** Asking the group to come back with ideas at the next meeting.
   - **C.** Deciding that it is not important.
   - **D.** Naming an owner and a deadline, or naming two people and a time to discuss it after the huddle.

Upskill Challenge

Before you start your next working day, prepare your plan. On a single page, write each item on one line and mark what truly has to be done today and what it affects. Choose your first item.

Write a four-line brief for one instruction you have received recently: outcome, steps, deadline, checkpoints.

Write a handover message using the three pieces of rhythm: first check-in, what each side will have ready, how the colleague reaches you, and one authority line on what you will escalate.

Run one short huddle or team stand-up in whatever form your team uses, and close every item with an owner and a deadline.

If you are not yet an Assistant Manager, use your own work list, delegate to yourself with the same steps, and run one short check-in with a colleague.

At the end of the day, write three lines: what you planned, what you actually did, and what you will move to tomorrow.

Model Answers

1. Sample response. "Outcome: confirmed delivery date for the north customer, in writing. Steps: check stock with the warehouse, call the customer with the date, note the answer on the account. Deadline: Wednesday noon. Checkpoints: I will check with you Wednesday morning before the call." I write it to my manager and copy the colleague who will help, so both know the same brief. Why it works: the four parts remove the questions before they are asked, and one short message keeps it light enough to send the same day.

2. Sample response. I start with the two customer items, because they have a hard noon deadline. I book a block for the three proposal items so they move today rather than on Friday. I clear the four small requests in one short gap after lunch, or I hand them to someone who can own them. Why it works: I am sorting by what truly has to be done and what it affects, not by the order things arrived.

3. Sample response. "First check-in is tomorrow at ten. You will have the draft and I will have the customer's last email. If a price change comes up, do not agree it. Message me and I will escalate it with a recommendation the same day. If you cannot reach me, call me, or message my manager." Why it works: the rhythm is agreed before the handover ends, and the authority line is stated plainly, so no one has to guess.

4. Sample response. "Before we close, who owns it and by when?" If more discussion is needed, I say, "That needs more time. You two take it after the huddle at ten-thirty, and bring back an owner and a deadline." Why it works: every item ends with an owner and a deadline, and the huddle stays short.

5. Sample response. I say plainly that the approval is outside my authority, and I do not give it. I write: "This change is outside what I can approve. I am sending it to my manager today with my recommendation, and I will let you know the answer by lunchtime tomorrow." Why it works: I never promise or approve something outside my authority, and I escalate early with a recommendation instead of leaving the customer waiting.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. A. The item that is both urgent now and important goes first; noise alone is not a reason.
- 2. C. The closing block closes open loops and sets your first item, which gives your mind permission to stop.
- 3. B. Outcome, steps, deadline and checkpoints answer the four questions that prevent guessing.
- 4. B. An agreed rhythm tells the colleague when the next contact happens and how to reach you.

- 5. D. An item with no owner and no deadline comes back tomorrow; close it with an owner and a deadline, or with two named people and a time to discuss it.

References

Kahneman, D. (2011). Thinking, Fast and Slow. Farrar, Straus and Giroux.

Locke, E. A., & Latham, G. P. (2002). Building a practically useful theory of goal setting and task motivation: A 35-year odyssey. American Psychologist, 57(9), 705–717.

Covey, S. R. (1989). The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People. Free Press.